the military establishment. Concrete examples of his mental decline occurred on several outings during 1992. Some speculate that at some point Saw Maung suffered a nervous breakdown. He had threatened to shoot several of his generals during a golf outing and repeatedly made claims to be the early Burmese King Kyanzittha. This later claim was repeated in a speech broadcast on television. In that same broadcast, he denied being a practitioner of black magic and claimed that martial law equaled no law at all. In addition, Saw Maung also struggled with diabetes and alcoholism. Maung became violent at times and during several fits of rage he was known to throw furniture and actually injured himself during one particular bout. At one press conference, the leader ranted and raved about the differences between Christianity and Buddhism. His embarrassing behavior led journalist John Casey to claim that Saw Maung was a buffoon. Some pundits speculate that the awarding of the Nobel Peace Prize to Aung San Suu Kyi may have helped to push Saw Maung over the edge. Rumors were circulating early in his reign that several keys generals were planning on replacing the unstable leader. Within Myanmar, one rumor circulated that fellow generals Khin Nyunt and Than Shwe had drugged Saw Maung. Another version of the events leading up to Saw Maung's demise proposes that Nyunt and Shwe collaborated together to bring down Saw Maung. Military intelligence agents contacted regional commanders to inform them of the proposed replacement of Saw Maung based on his irrational behavior. Informed of the decision to replace him, Saw Maung quietly went into retirement in March 1992. His official resignation cited health reasons.

A supposed power struggle emerged between Khin Nyunt, a close confidant of Ne Win, who held the position of head of military intelligence, and Than Shwe, who had already positioned himself in line behind Saw Maung. In April, General Than Shwe emerged victorious in a leadership struggle over Khin Nyunt. Speculation abounds that Nyunt encouraged Than Shwe to take the top spot in the belief that he would not last long. This view was widely circulated as many visiting diplomats speculated that Than Shwe would be a short-term leader. Khin Nyunt believed that he could overtake Shwe easily in due course. Than Shwe was considered less ambitious, more conservative, and less of a threat to the military establishment. Many within the ranks of the military were shocked at his takeover because he was not considered to have the intellect to hold the position. Than Shwe, it seemed, wanted to be underestimated by his